

A LESSON FOR BUSINESS OWNERS

Why AI Alone Won't Make You Money in 24 Hours

A real experiment — and what it teaches every business owner about using AI.

THE HYPE

The promise we've all been sold

- "Spin up an AI app this weekend → passive income."
- "No skills, no audience, no budget — let AI do it all."
- It's everywhere because it **sells courses**, not because it's true.

THE EXPERIMENT

So we put it to the test

"Research a way to make a product that generates revenue, in 24 hours. £0 budget, no audience."

We gave that brief to a top AI — and let it run: real research, real sources, a real recommendation.

THE GOOD NEWS

What the AI did brilliantly

- Ran **5 research streams** in parallel, read **dozens of sources**.
- Compared product types, sales channels and payment tools.
- Found real case studies and the fastest path to go live.
- Delivered a **cited, end-to-end recommendation** — ready to act on.

For research and drafting, AI is genuinely superhuman. Hold that thought.

THE CATCH

Then we hit the same wall, every time

- Every "overnight success" had a **hidden head start**.
- One famous builder sold his product **90 minutes** after launch...
- ...to an audience of **~500,000 followers** built over 10 years.
- The "overnight" success actually took a **decade**.

SURVIVORSHIP BIAS · REAL POSTS, NOT CHERRY-PICKED

The myth, in data

INDIE HACKERS

"I built a SaaS in 9 days for \$200, launched on HN to **zero signups** — here's what actually happened." source: indiehackers.com

INDIE HACKERS

"I built a SaaS in 10 days. 3 weeks live. **0 paying customers**. Here's the data." source: indiehackers.com

INDIE HACKERS

"400 signups from Product Hunt, **1 paying customer** — what 4 days taught me about launch vs traction." source: indiehackers.com

THE PATTERN

For every "made \$X in a day" there are piles of these. **You only ever see the winners.** source: survivorship bias

REALITY CHECK

Even when you *do* sell — the cash is days away

STRIPE

First payout typically lands **7–14 days** after your first successful charge. source: support.stripe.com

GUMROAD

A **7-day hold** on sales, then payouts only **every Friday**.
source: help.gumroad.com

LEMON SQUEEZY

Net sales held **13 days**, then paid out only on the 14th & 28th. source: docs.lemonsqueezy.com

PAYPAL

New sellers: payments can be held for **up to 21 days**.
source: paypal.com

"Go live in 24 hours" is realistic. "Money in the bank in 24 hours" is not.

THE WHOLE LESSON ON ONE LINE

The real equation

$$\text{Revenue} = \text{Product} \times \text{Distribution} \times \text{Trust}$$

- AI is a rocket on **Product**.
- It barely touches **Distribution** and **Trust**.
- Multiply by zero on either — and you get **zero**.

MAKE VS. SELL

What AI can and can't do

✓ AI COMPRESSES (WEEKS → HOURS)

- Research & market analysis
- Building the product / site / tool
- Writing content, emails, listings
- Designs and graphics

✗ AI CAN'T SHORTCUT (STILL TAKES TIME)

- An audience that knows you exist
- Trust that you'll deliver
- Relationships & reputation
- Real, proven demand

SO HERE'S THE HONEST PART

Full disclosure: I had a head start too

When I ran this experiment, I wasn't starting from zero either:

- I **already had products on sale** — live apps, built long before today.
- A studio, a brand and a **warm network** — a route to market most people don't have.
- Accounts, payments, tooling and skills — all **set up years ago**.
- The AI plugged into all of that. It was never a **"day-1" setup**.

The AI **accelerated a business that already existed** — and the good news is **you can build that foundation too**.

THE "QUICK WIN" MYTH

And even my shortcut isn't instant

- I *could* sell **Wix Studio templates** — a genuine route to market for me.
- But that route **took time to set up**: account, store, brand, process.
- And building one good template in Wix Studio is **not instant** either.

"Fast" still meant **days of real work** — on top of **years** of foundation. So what *can* you realistically do today?

AIM TO GO LIVE, NOT TO "GET RICH"

So what CAN you do in 24 hours?

- **Warm** — sell to people who already trust you (past clients, network).
- **Productised** — one fixed offer, one fixed price, decided in one message.
- **Pre-sell** — take payment on the promise before you build.
- Warm leads convert **60–70%** vs. **5–20%** cold.

THE LEVERAGE MOVE

The smart way to use AI

- Let it **research** the market and the offer.
- Let it **build** the thing fast.
- Let it **produce your content** on autopilot — so your audience grows in the background.

AI doesn't replace the slow work of building trust — it buys you the **time** to do it.

TAKEAWAYS

The lesson

- AI is an **accelerant**, not a market.
- **Speed of building** $\neq$ **speed of selling**.
- Your **audience & network** are the real asset.
- **Sell before you build**.

EXERCISE

Your turn

Don't ask AI *"what can I sell?"* Ask:

"Here's who already trusts me [list them]. Here's what I'm good at. Design one fixed-price offer I could message them today — and write the message."

Bring the offer to the next session.

CLOSE

AI gives you superpowers on the build. The business is still yours to earn.

Use the superpower for what it's good at — then go do the human part. That's still where the money is.